

MEG

What Is a Variable?

The vocabulary that unlocks every equation.

Variable

x, y, n

A symbol (usually a letter) that represents an unknown quantity.

Example: $3x + 7$ — the letter stands in for a number we don't know yet.

Constant

$5, -3, \frac{1}{2}$

A fixed number that does not change.

Example: In $3x + 7$, the constant is 7.

Coefficient

multiplies

The number multiplied by a variable.

Example: In $4x$, the coefficient is 4.

Expression

no equals

A combination of variables, constants, and operations — with no equals sign.

Example: $3x + 7$

REMEMBER A variable is a placeholder — its value can change.